Juliette's Journal

By Tahereh Mafi

(Pg 177+) We had homes. Before. We bought lawn ornaments and twinkle lights and learned to ride bikes without training wheels. I remember televisions and fireplaces and porcelain sinks. I remember movie tickets and parking lots and SUVs. I remember hair salons and holidays and toothpaste commercials; ladies in high heels and old men in business suits. I remember mailmen and libraries and boy bands and balloons and Christmas trees. We ate the things we shouldn't, spent money when we couldn't, lost sight of the Earth we had to inhabit, and wasted . . . wasted . . . wasted ***everything***. Food. Water. Resources.

I remember being 10 years old when we couldn't ignore the food shortages anymore and things got so expensive no one could afford to live.

Soon the skies were gray with chemical pollution and the plants and animals were sick from genetic modification, and diseases rooted themselves in our air, our meals, our

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blood and bones. The food disappeared. People were dying. Our empire fell to pieces.

The Reestablishment said they would help us. Save us. Rebuild our society. Instead they tore us all apart.

INTRODUCTION

In a crumbling world under the dictatorship of the Reestablishment, 17-year-old Juliette Ferrars is locked away in a cell. She is not an ordinary teenager. In fact, she is a lethal one. A touch from her can kill.

When she was fourteen, she accidentally killed a little boy. He had tripped and fallen, and Juliette was just trying to help, but people believed that she choked the little boy to death. Juliette has been locked away ever since. For the Reestablishment, she is as much a threat as she is ***potentially*** *the ultimate weapon.*

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I keep thinking I need to stay calm, that it's all in my head, that everything is going to be fine and someone is going to open the door, someone is going to let me out of here. Things like this don't just happen. People aren't forgotten like this. Not abandoned like this. This doesn't just happen. *(SCREAMS, SCREAMS, SCREAMS, but there is no response)*

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(Breathless) There are a million screams caught inside of my chest but what's the point of screaming if you'll never be heard and no one will ever hear me in here. No one will ever hear me ever again.

It's a strange thing, to never know peace. To know that no matter where you go, there is no sanctuary. That the threat of pain is always a whisper away. I'm not safe locked into these 4 walls, I was never safe leaving my house, and I couldn't even feel safe in the 14 years I lived at home.

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The asylum kills people every day, the world has already been taught to fear me, and my home is the same place where my father locked me in my room every night and my mother screamed at me for being the abomination she was forced to raise.

She always said it was my face. There was something about my face, she said, that she couldn't stand. Something about my eyes, the way I looked at her, the fact that I even existed. She'd always tell me to stop looking at her. She'd always scream it. Like I might attack her. Stop looking at me, she'd scream. You just stop looking at me, she'd scream.

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I don't know when it started. I don't know why it started. I don't know anything about anything except for the screaming.

My mother screaming when she realized she could no longer touch me. My father screaming when he realized what I'd done to my mother. My parents screaming when they'd lock me in my room and tell me I should be grateful. For their food. For their humane treatment of this thing that could not possibly be their child. For the yardstick they used to measure the distance I needed to keep away.

I ruined their lives, is what they said to me. I stole their happiness. Destroyed my mother's hope for ever having children again.

Couldn't I see what I'd done? is what they'd ask me. Couldn't I see that I'd ruined everything? I tried so hard to fix what I'd ruined. I tried every single day to be what they wanted. I tried all the time to be better but I never really knew how.

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She put my hand in the fire once. Just to see it would burn, she said. Just to check if it was a regular hand, she

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said. I was 6 years old then. I remember because it was my birthday.

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I wonder what they're thinking. My parents. I wonder where they are. I wonder if they're okay now, if they're happy now, if they finally got what they wanted. I wonder if my mother will ever have another child. I wonder if someone will ever be kind enough to kill me and I wonder if hell is better than here. I wonder if I'll ever breathe fresh air again. I wonder about so many things. *(Listens intently)*

I wonder who else is locked in this asylum. I wonder where the other screams are coming from. . . *(Puts her hand to her lips and then to her throat)* I wonder if they're coming from me.

There's something simmering inside of me. Something I've never dared to tap into, something I'm afraid to acknowledge. There's a part of me clawing to break free from the cage I've trapped it in, banging on the doors of my heart begging to be free.Begging to let go.

Every day I feel like I'm reliving the same nightmare. I open my mouth to shout, to fight, to swing my fists but my vocal chords are cut, my arms are heavy and weighted

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down as if trapped in wet cement and I'm screaming but no one can hear me, no one can reach me and I'm caught. And it's killing me.

I've always had to make myself submissive, subservient, twisted into a pleading, passive mop just to make everyone else feel safe and comfortable. My existence has become a fight to prove I'm harmless, that I'm not a threat, that I'm capable of living among other human beings without hurting them.

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I don't know what's happening to me.

Sometimes I think the shadows are moving.

Sometimes I think someone might be watching.

Sometimes this idea scares me and sometimes the idea makes me so absurdly happy I can't stop crying. And then sometimes I think I have no idea when I started losing my mind in here. Nothing seems real anymore and I can't tell if I'm screaming out loud or only in my head.

There's no one here to hear me.

To tell me I'm not dead.

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Hate.

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It's poison, an unrelenting punch to the gut, an injustice injected directly into your bloodstream that slowly paralyzes your organs until you can't breathe

you can't

breathe

because loneliness has stuffed itself into your clothes and you're rotting to death in a dark corner of the world and you're already forgotten.

You never even were.

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Loneliness is a strange sort of thing.

It creeps up on you, quiet and still, sits by your side in the dark, strokes your hair as you sleep. It wraps itself around your bones, squeezing so tight you almost can't breathe, almost can't hear the pulse racing in your blood as it rushes up your skin and touches its lips to the soft hairs at the back of your neck. It leaves lies in your heart, lies next to you at night, leeches the light out from every corner. It's a constant companion, clasping your hand only to yank you down when you're struggling to stand up, catching your tears only to force them down your throat. It scares you simply by standing by your side.

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You wake up in the morning and wonder who you are. You fail to fall asleep at night and tremble in your skin. Loneliness is an old friend standing beside you in the mirror, looking you in the eye, challenging you to live your life without it. You can't find the words to fight yourself, to fight the words screaming that you're not enough never enough never ever enough.

Loneliness is a bitter, wretched companion. Sometimes it just won't let go.

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I close my eyes and try to remember a world beyond these walls. I wonder what it would be like to know that I'm not dreaming, that this isolated existence is not caged within my own mind.

And I do. I do I wonder, I think about it all the time.

What it would be like to kill myself.

Because I never really know, I still can't tell the difference, I'm never quite certain whether or not I'm actually alive.

So I sit here.

I sit here every day.

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Run, I said to myself.

Run until your lungs collapse, until the wind whips and snaps at your tattered clothes, until you're a blur that blends into the background.

Run, Juliette, run faster, run until your bones break and your shins split and your muscles atrophy and your heart dies because it was always too big for your chest and it beat too fast for too long and run.

Run run run until you can't hear their feet behind you. Run until they drop their fists and their shouts dissolve in the air. Run with your eyes open and your mouth shut and darn the river rushing up behind your eyes. Run, Juliette.

Run until you drop dead.

Make sure your heart stops before they ever reach you. Before they ever touch you.

Run, I said.

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Why don't you just kill yourself? someone at school asked me once.

I think it was the kind of question intended to be cruel, but it was the first time I ever contemplated the possibility. I didn't know what to say. Maybe I was crazy to consider it,

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but I always hoped that if I were a good enough girl—if I did everything right, if I said the right things or said nothing at all—I thought my parents would change their minds. I thought they would finally listen when I tried to talk. I thought they would give me a chance. I thought they might finally love me.

I always had hope.

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I remember televisions and fireplaces and porcelain sinks . . .

I remember movie tickets and parking lots and SUVs . . .

I remember hair salons and holidays and toothpaste commercials;

ladies in high heels and old men in business suits . . .

I remember mailmen and libraries and boy bands and balloons and Christmas trees . . .

[I remember hope]

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